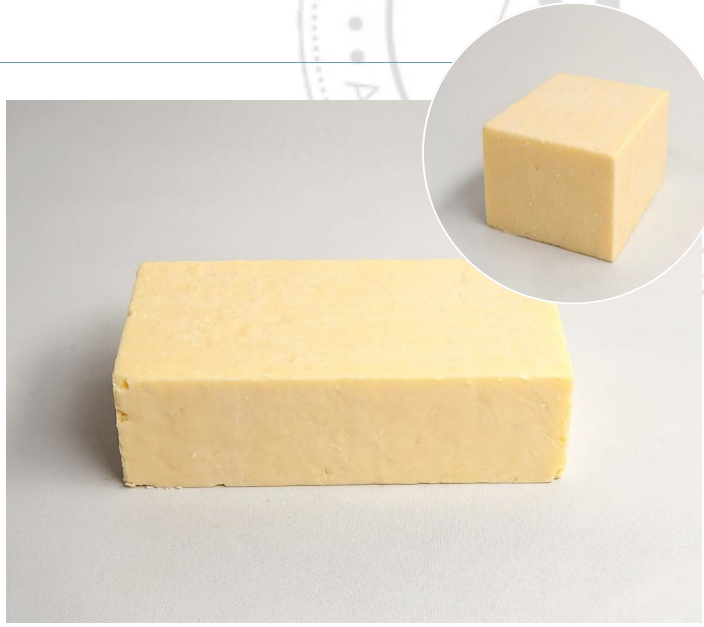
BLOCK CHEDDAR



THE BASICS

MAKE:	Hard
POST-MAKE:	Wrapped, Rolled or Processed
SUB POST-MAKE:	Artificial (plastic coating, wax coat, matured in vacuum pack)
TYPICAL AGE PROFILE:	Various
APPROXIMATE WEIGHT(S):	18kg
GEOGRAPHICAL ORIGIN:	UK, but the name 'cheddar' is not protected so is made in many countries throughout the world
PROTECTED STATUS:	N/A
SPECIES OF MILKING ANIMAL:	Cow
BREED OF COW:	Various, typically Holstein Friesian
RAW/PASTEURISED MILK:	Pasteurised
VEGETARIAN/ANIMAL RENNET:	Typically vegetarian rennet
COMMONLY ENCOUNTERED VARIATIONS:	N/A

THE STORY

There is no protected status for the term 'cheddar', so the cheese can and is made anywhere. While round truckles of farmhouse cheddar are often cloth-bound and made with raw milk, block cheddar is made on a much larger scale in factories using pasteurised milk.

The cheddaring process for artisan cheeses, which involves stacking blocks of curd by hand to help drain whey, is carried out in automated machines for block cheeses with capacities of up to 15 tonnes per hour. The 18kg cheeses, which are formed into straight-edged blocks to make cutting easier, are matured in sealed plastic bags to stop a rind from forming and to prevent weight loss.

THE CHARACTER

There are no legal definitions for cheddar ageing terms. However, the British Cheese Board says: 'mild' cheddar is typically sold at three months; 'medium' at six months; 'mature' at nine months; 'extra mature' at 15 months; and 'vintage' at 18 months or more.

The texture is typically moist, smooth and consistent with flavours including sweet and dairy notes with some sharpness.

PERFECT PARTNERS:

Great for sandwiches and melting on toast or pasta. Bitter beers are a traditional accompaniment.

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